

HOW TO PROTECT KIDS FROM RISKY **SMART TOYS**



(Credit: www.woobo.io)

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Toys and technology do not seem to blend well when it comes to kids' toys, especially connected smart toys. A general notion prevails that replacing a real playmate with interactive technology can have behavioural or social implications. However, adoption of smart toys is gradually increasing despite negative views. There is increasing awareness that benefits these offer outweigh the harm these cause.

Smart toys are educational and interactive in nature, and help in the intellectual development of a child at an early age. Besides, these improve the child's social as well as language skills in an entertaining way.

As far as security risks are concerned, these can be mitigated if consumers do their research

cautiously and are aware of necessary precautions. Notably, demand for smart toys in India is increasing considerably, but these are still not comparable with regular toys. Demand for such smart toys comes majorly from big cities like New Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad.

Benefits of smart toys

Smart or connected toys have various benefits over normal toys that have existed for years. These are effective in improving the child's learning ability and compel the child to think intelligently and analytically from a tender age.

These can stir interests in children and engage them in productive ways during playtime. Connected toys are equipped with built-in motion sensors, microphones, cameras and speakers that react to children's needs by analysing what they say or ask. These provide answers either through text, or by speaking to them within seconds by searching online databases or the Internet.

These toys can figure out the child's area of interest or preference over time;

accordingly, games can be personalised, which leads to further learning for the child. Besides, artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled toys and apps connected to the Internet can assess the knowledge level of the child and automatically upgrade to the level suitable for the child.

Most importantly, smart toys prove to be effective in dealing with kids struggling with intellectual disabilities. Such children are much more receptive to the teaching of social studies concepts through smart toys. They exhibit keenness to learn and communicate with others, too. Basically, smart toys help such kids overcome social barriers and facilitate them to learn with much enjoyment.

Additionally, connected toys allow parents to track location of their kid(s), and set up alerts for safe and unsafe places.

Risks associated

Hi-tech toys can make playtime more interesting and educative. Nevertheless, these are vulnerable to invasive